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February 2, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

It is my pleasure to nominate Raquel Zandomeneghi for the Distinguished Teaching Award as a TA serving in our department. Raquel is a four-year graduate student in the Department of Spanish and Portuguese specializing in Afro-Luso Brazilian Studies, and with an especial interest in the literatures of Brazil and the Southern Cone, especially, of Argentina.

I have known Raquel since entering our Ph.D. program in Hispanic Languages and Literatures and I have her in one of my seminars as a student, and later I served in her advisory committee for the Capstone examination, and more recently serving as a member of her dissertation committee. That is, I know her very well, and during all these years I got to know that not only is she a superb graduate student, but she is also an incredibly skillful and hardworking educator. As a TA she has excelled in each of the classes she has taught, during each quarter of the academic year, during our study abroad program in Granada, and during the summer sessions at UCLA. A remarkable aspect of Raquel's teaching is that she has been extraordinary at teaching both Portuguese and Spanish alike. Just imagine a TA who could teach every level of Portuguese, including in advanced sessions, and then move smoothly between them and any level of Spanish needed in the department, and do all that with the same level of joy and efficiency, making students learning and success a given.

The Committee of Undergraduate Affairs, chaired by my colleague Prof. Javier Patiño Loira met to discuss the different excellent candidates and decided to propose Raquel Zandomeneghi as the stand out candidate among the pool, and later on, the faculty body decided to support the nomination unanimously. I couldn't be more thrilled when I learned the support for Raquel, since I completely concurred and I enthusiastically support her nomination.

For all these reasons, and a discussion in which all faculty expressed their opinion, we have decided to nominate Raquel Zandomeneghi to the 2026 Distinguished Teaching Award. As chair of the Department of Spanish and Portuguese, let me insist not only in my enthusiastic endorsement of my colleagues' opinion, but also in my delight to support Raquel without any reservation whatsoever for this award. She is the brightest example among the TAs in the department and somebody who deserves to be recognized as such.

Please don't hesitate to contact me in case you need further information (either by email: marturano@humnet.ucla.edu or by phone: 216 789 4793).

Sincerely,



Jorge Marturano
Associate Professor and Chair
Dept. of Spanish and Portuguese, UCLA

Self-Statement

As a Teaching Assistant in the Department of Spanish and Portuguese, I have taught across multiple instructional contexts, including different levels of Portuguese and Spanish language courses—both on campus and in a study abroad program—, as well as classes on Latin American culture and Brazil and the Portuguese-speaking world. Throughout my time as a TA, spanning seven academic quarters and two summer sessions, I have implemented inclusive, student-centered teaching practices, fostering a learning environment in which each student feels they belong in the classroom, and that they are active actors of knowledge. These efforts were recognized by my department, which awarded me the Rookie Teaching Assistant of the Year Award (2023–2024). This is also reflected in my course evaluations (see Artifact 1), in which students describe me as an empathetic, enthusiastic, engaging, and approachable instructor. They note that this inclusive environment made them feel more comfortable participating in class and attending office hours, which enhanced their overall learning. Students who typically do not feel comfortable participating, or who previously had negative experiences with the language in other classes, state that my course made them feel welcomed and helped them overcome those past experiences. The comments also emphasize my ongoing efforts to check in on students' comfort levels, invite them to office hours, and provide additional materials to support their learning. They further highlight how central student interaction and discussion are in my classes.

My teaching strategies vary according to the course. In culture classes where I am not the main instructor, I structure my sections based on students' needs and the material covered in lecture. For example, in Spanish 44 – Latin American Cultures, my sections emphasized close readings, while in Portuguese 46 – Brazil and the Portuguese-Speaking World I focused on providing historical context. In both cases, after a brief introduction, students lead most of the discussion, working in pairs or trios. In language classes, my approach centers on activities that integrate the four skills—reading, speaking, writing, and listening—while engaging with cultural content. Across all courses, I prioritize collaborative learning, often using small groups discussions, peer-review activities (see Artifact 2), Think-Pair-Share, etc. I also incorporate cross-cultural comparisons to value students' existing knowledge, foster respect for other cultures, and challenge stereotypes (see Artifact 3). By encouraging cross-cultural comparisons between course materials and students' own social environments, I intend to help students ground new concepts in familiar contexts and develop deeper understanding.

When preparing a language course, I review materials from previous classes to identify activities that worked well and reconsider those that did not. For example, when teaching Spanish 1 last summer, I revisited my Portuguese 1 materials and reflected on my approach to the first classes of a level 1 course. In Portuguese, I had previously avoided activities that practiced all four competences (reading, speaking, listening, and writing) at the very beginning, assuming students were not yet prepared for them. In Spanish 1, however, I intentionally incorporated these activities from the first classes. As a result, students became more balanced and confident across all competences throughout the course. I also adjust activities based on

recurring student difficulties, incorporate my supervisor's feedback—such as better integrating textbook themes into grammar practice. Finally, I value student feedback: after a student suggested reviewing dates, timelines, and key figures from lectures (see Artifact 1), I plan to incorporate this practice into future culture classes.

After realizing that Portuguese students at UCLA had few opportunities to practice the language outside class, I founded and facilitated the Portuguese Club, where students of varying proficiency levels could practice in a low-pressure environment. I have also participated in four departmental workshops on topics ranging from teaching intermediate and advanced Spanish and Portuguese to equitable grading and artificial intelligence in the classroom. The AI workshop focused on effective and inappropriate uses of AI tools in language teaching, inspiring me to design two in-class activities using AI (see one example in Artifact 4)—which students recognized as both innovative and engaging. Teaching a blind student in Spanish 2 and 3 also prompted me to study accessibility carefully, including best-practices for alt-text, slides and documents, ensuring that my materials were fully accessible while still serving the needs of a language classroom (see Artifact 5).

Teaching Philosophy Statement

As an immigrant, I understand how uncomfortable it can be to speak in public in a non-native language, particularly in formal and professional contexts. This awareness shapes my teaching practice as an instructor of Portuguese and Spanish language courses, as well as classes on Latin American cultures and the Brazilian and Portuguese-speaking world. I strive to create classroom environments in which students feel a sense of belonging and understand that making grammatical mistakes is acceptable and an essential part of the language-learning process. Beyond fostering a welcoming space for language risk-taking, I also aim to encourage students to engage respectfully with cultures different from their own. Learning new languages and cultures promotes empathy, respect, and social consciousness, and, as an educator, I am committed to cultivating these values in my students.

Throughout my trajectory as a Teaching Assistant at UCLA, I have become increasingly interested in pedagogy, drawing inspiration from Brazilian educator Paulo Freire, whose work emphasizes the importance of incorporating students' everyday contexts into the classroom in order to make learning more meaningful and, consequently, more student-centered. I believe that learning becomes enduring only when it connects to students' lived realities. In my courses, I bridge the gap between academic content and contemporary life by encouraging continuous cross-cultural comparisons. I frequently ask students to draw parallels between the cultural materials we study and their own social environments in the United States. By grounding new concepts in familiar contexts, this approach helps students connect prior knowledge to new perspectives and deepen their understanding.

From the very beginning of my courses, I make class expectations clear to students: they are expected to participate actively and engage fully in class activities. I emphasize that they will do most of the work, while my role is to facilitate activities, and support their learning rather than dominate the discussion. I view the diverse backgrounds of my students as my most valuable pedagogical resource. I actively design lessons that invite students to act as co-experts, validating their heritage and prior knowledge. During the Spanish 44 – Latin American Culture course, for instance, a Cuban student played a pivotal role in helping the class unpack the cultural nuances of a poem related to Caribbean sports culture. Similarly, in the Portuguese 46 – Brazil and Portuguese-Speaking World, I encourage Portuguese heritage speakers to help their peers understand the subtleties of a poem and its translation. In language classes, I compare Portuguese and Spanish vocabulary when appropriate, leveraging the linguistic knowledge of Spanish speakers to highlight differences and avoid false cognates. In practice, these strategies promote peer learning and create a classroom dynamic in which students' diverse experiences directly support comprehension and engagement.

Teaching SPAN 2 and 3 with a blind student was a formative experience that prompted growth in my pedagogical practice. Initially, I avoided visuals in shared slides to prevent screen reader complications; however, given the central role that images play in language learning as sources of vocabulary input and contextual meaning, I adopted a more inclusive approach. When visuals were pedagogically necessary, I provided accurate and complete alt-text descriptions,

allowing the student to participate fully in visual-based activities by interpreting in Spanish what images described in English conveyed. Working closely with her CAE specialist and the Vista Higher Learning platform, I revised exercises, assessments, and instructional materials to meet accessibility standards. This experience reinforced my understanding of accessibility as a fundamental, intentional component of student-centered teaching and exemplifies how I continually adapt my pedagogy to better meet the needs of all learners.

For me, feedback and grading are most effective when they help students understand how to improve their work and enhance their learning over time. My feedback methodology focuses on the student's trajectory over time. When reviewing assignments, I provide comprehensive feedback that connects the current work to their previous one, acknowledging specific areas of improvement while offering concrete strategies for the next assignment. My intention is to empower students by turning the path to improvement visible and achievable, making them feel more comfortable and confident of their potential. I integrate my teaching methods with careful attention to students' learning experiences, tracking their progress in class and on assessments. When I notice a disengaged student, I reach out to see how I can support their learning process.

My commitment to student development extends well beyond the physical classroom, a capability I fully realized during the summer of 2024 while serving as a Teaching Assistant for the UCLA study abroad program in Granada, Spain. In this role, my responsibilities shifted from purely academic instruction to holistic mentorship and crisis management. Living alongside the students, I acted as their primary support system, navigating them through the complexities of daily life in a foreign country—from facilitating cultural immersion tours to assisting them during medical emergencies and police reports after safety incidents. This supervision reinforced my belief that teaching is an act of care.

My work outside the classroom takes shape through service and mentorship as well. Last year, I founded and facilitated the Portuguese Club, creating an informal space for undergraduate and graduate students to practice the language and build community. I also support students by writing letters of recommendation for a variety of academic and professional opportunities. In particular, I mentored two students applying to study abroad programs in Brazil, both of whom successfully secured placement and scholarships.

I am grateful for the committee's consideration of my candidacy. Receiving the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award would be an honor, validating my dedication to a pedagogical practice that is grounded in inclusive, student-centered learning and supports the academic and personal growth of my students.

Artifact 1: Written comments from SET surveys

a) Students felt comfortable and welcomed both in class and during my office hours:

Raquel is a very kind instructor who has a welcoming personality that is crucial for effective language learning classes. She was incredibly caring and considerate about all of us and our learning. For example, when I went to her office hours to discuss a question I had regarding a Spanish grammatical structure, she patiently explained it to me. After her office hours, I developed a better understanding of the structure. However, Raquel went beyond this, and sent me a follow–up email with additional resources that I could access and study with to further develop my understanding of the subject, as well as a re–explanation of the structure we discussed. I found this act to be very thoughtful! She was also very accommodating to students' situations and did her best to alter the course to best fit our learning needs and capacities at each given time. Furthermore, she taught Spanish in a fun, humorous manner that made it less daunting to ask clarifying questions whenever necessary. Even when you made a mistake during class discussions (ex: wrong noun or verb conjugation), she was sure to correct it gently and in a constructive manner that never made anyone feel bad.

- Raquel fixed my negative experiences with Portuguese. She is nice but fair with her students. I can't recommend her enough!
- Raquel is an extremely kind, caring and thoughtful instructor! After having a negative portuguese course experience previously, I was apprehensive about taking another Portuguese course. However, I am so glad I decided to take Raquel's class. She always made me feel comfortable asking questions and being vulnerable, which I so appreciated when learning a new language. Her classroom environment was always warm and welcoming. Raquel is great!!! <3 :)

Raquel was an excellent TA for spanish this quarter. She genuinely concerns herself with student learning and prioritizes making her class a welcoming and inclusive environment for students. Spanish is very intimidating for me, but Raquel always found ways to incorporate entertaining activities that promoted learning. If I could retake the class with her again, I would. Raquel knows how to connect with her students and simplify concepts that are difficult into a digestable format!

- My teacher is very understanding and patient with the class. She also cares about her students personal needs to ensure their academic success. I really enjoyed going to class, as she was very friendly and considerate. However, I do struggle with speaking in class because I get very anxious which can be discouraging but my teacher reached out and offered additional support to practice one on one which I appreciate.

- My Portuguese teacher, Ms.Raquel, is always very positive and helpful during class and outside of class. Her lectures are very organized and engaging. She's continues her engaging nature with the class, by getting students to get out of their comfort zone to learn another language. She gives us plenty of time to discuss our material with peers to practice our oral skills. Furthermore, she helps develop our confidence by offering individual practice with her. She was kind enough to extend her office hours to discuss the struggles I had with the class material. She did an amazing job explaining the course material and where I went wrong. I felt extremely comfortable the entire time and would go back for help when needed. I learned very insightful information this quarter and I'm very thrilled to continue to learn the language with her.

Raquel was the best Spanish TA I had throughout all of Spanish 1,2, and 3. She was always super fun and enthusiastic, and I loved how she never stopped trying to get the class to engage, even though sometimes it was difficult. She was empathetic towards students during hard topics, and always made to emphasize topics that she knew were going to be difficult. She always answered every question throroughly and made learning easy and fun. I actually looked forward to coming to Spanish, and I think that says a lot about her ability to connect with students

I feel a strength she had was that she made learning Spanish and asking for help not intimidating. She was always very helpful and made learning fun. She was very organized and provided many different activities where we could practice our Spanish. She was very encouraging and always had a great attitude which provided us with a fun and entertaining learning environment. I feel that was strength of this course were the Vhl lessons as I was able to work at my own pace and be able to go back to the lessons if I needed clarification.

- Raquel was always concerned with how well everyone was learning and would ask questions to check in with each person. She would show cultural snapshots when covering certain topics and then reinforce them with real world experiences/stories. I felt like the pacing is fast for learning a language but that is not the instructors fault it is the nature of the class. overall Raquel is an amazing teacher and would recommend anyone who has a language requirement to take her Portuguese class.

Raquelle is excellent at engaging the class (those who show up), even though a lot of students are not eager to speak up in Spanish because it is uncomfortable. On the first day, she had a lot of enthusiasm that set the tone for the rest of the year, making everyone feel safe and free of judgement. Every time I asked her a question, she immediately addressed it by writing down the correct word or conjugation on the board. I felt very comfortable approaching her outside of class, and she was very accomodating with scheduling and deadlines. This was the best experience that I have had in a Spanish class this far because it was both fun, and I learned the most. This is the most comfortable that I have ever felt while speaking spanish.

b) Students experienced engaging, interactive, active-learning classes:

- Raquel is an amazing TA. Her class activities involved us participating conversations in Portuguese with our peers. I believe her discussion prompts improved our class's proficiency in the language. She also incorporates several in-class listening and reading activities as well to help improve our other skills in the language. Raquel is very friendly and approachable as a TA, and she cares about her student's success.

Raquel is literally my favorite TA of all time she made learning so much easier and she made section so fun this class was a lot of work but but she made it doable because I looked forward to class with her all of the time. She gave us options on how to learn the material, had variety with listening excercises, working in groups, etc. She is the best I would take any class with her as the TA no joke. It was so useful to my learning and she had fun examples and helped us to expand while also acknowledging our beginner level. Great start to finish no notes.

- Very engaging and acknowledges every single student. Promotes group discussion and is very interactive with the class.
- great ta!! very friendly and engaging, and her discussions always helped me understand the readings a lot better. also very responsive and cares a lot about helping her students succeed. i really appreciate her time and effort
- Raquel fosters a fun and engaging environment which encourages participation and active learning. As an instructor, she prepares well-organized lectures that always include new and relevant materials. Even when if participation was lacking on certain days she found ways to make the class worthwhile and beneficial.

Raquel is a great TA and amazing at keeping the class engaged in practicing Spanish with each other.

Raquel was very personable and she ran discussions in a very engaging and charming way. I appreciated how she remembered everyone's names and took the time to care about them outside of a class context as well. Her mini discussion lectures complemented Professor Lino's main lectures very well, and she incorporated a lot of class discussion and conversation, which I appreciated.

- She is great at encouraging everyone to participate and is very welcoming of different opinions.
- Raquel is very knowledgeable on the material she is teaching, and all of Latin American History. She is very kind and funny and a good TA who works hard to get students to participate in class and make sure we all understand the material.

c) Other relevant comments:

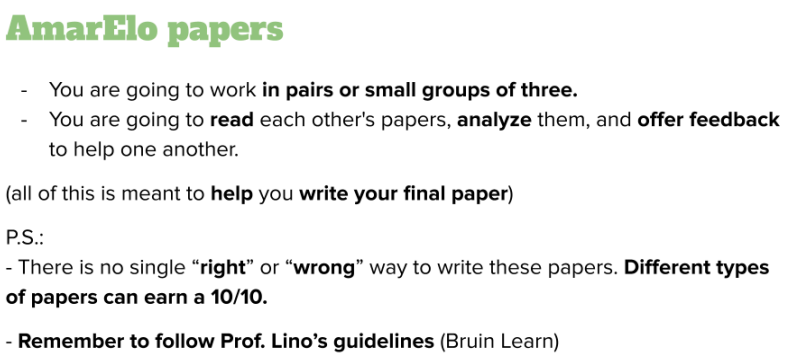
Absolutely loved her as my TA, and by far one of the BEST I have had in my 2 years here in UCLA. She n ot only knows the content by heart but also ensures that we as students completely grasps the topics. Even at 9am she made discussion feel totally entertaining. Highly recommend!

- i really enjoyed this class. you were very relatable which was the reason I felt so comfortable in class. because I was comfortable with you and my classmates I felt open to participate.

I enjoyed this discussion section and found it very helpful to my work in the course. In discussion the focus was often on expanding on an idea or concept that maybe wasn't fully developed in class, which I found interesting and helpful. Raquel was very knowledgeable about the material and was able to offer another perspective that added to my understanding of course ideas. She was very welcoming and encouraged participation in discussion, and provided constructive, helpful feedback on the response papers we wrote each week. I didn't have any particular issues with the discussion, perhaps a bit more emphasis could be placed on the dates, timeline, and names involved, coming from someone with hardly any prior knowledge of course concepts, but overall I found this discussion section helpful and engaging.

Artifact 2: Peer-review

In Portuguese 46 – Brazil and Portuguese-Speaking World, I realized that students were not necessarily struggling with the course content itself, but rather with writing the weekly reflection papers. Although I provided detailed and individualized feedback, I recognized that reading and engaging with their peers' work could further support their writing process, especially in preparation for the final paper. Therefore, most of the discussion section of that week was spent on the following activity:



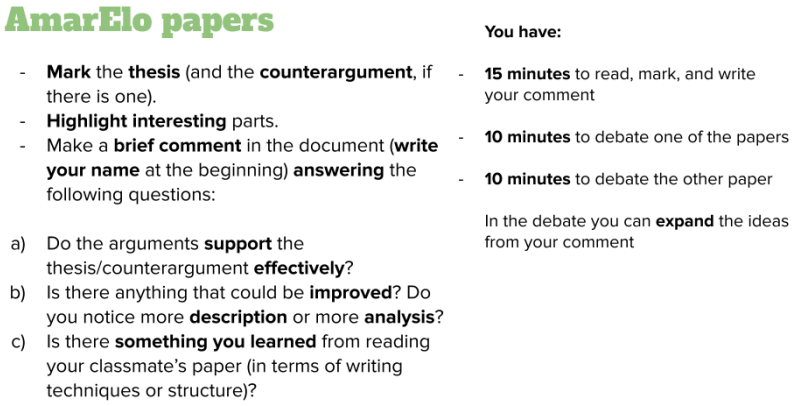
AmarElo papers

- You are going to work **in pairs or small groups of three.**
- You are going to **read** each other's papers, **analyze** them, and **offer feedback** to help one another.

(all of this is meant to **help** you **write your final paper**)

P.S.:
- There is no single "**right**" or "**wrong**" way to write these papers. **Different types of papers can earn a 10/10.**

- **Remember to follow Prof. Lino's guidelines** (Bruin Learn)



AmarElo papers

- **Mark** the **thesis** (and the **counterargument**, if there is one).
- **Highlight interesting** parts.
- Make a **brief comment** in the document (**write your name** at the beginning) **answering** the following questions:

a) Do the arguments **support** the thesis/counterargument **effectively**?
b) Is there anything that could be **improved**? Do you notice more **description** or more **analysis**?
c) Is there **something you learned** from reading your classmate's paper (in terms of writing techniques or structure)?

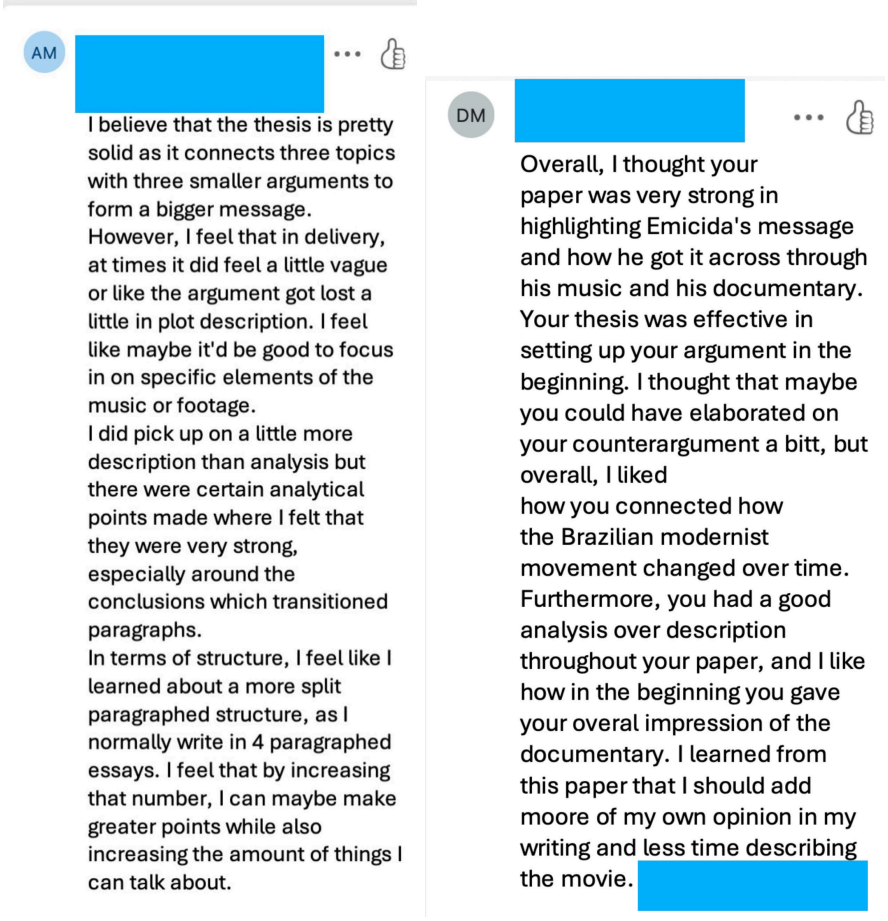
You have:

- **15 minutes** to read, mark, and write your comment
- **10 minutes** to debate one of the papers
- **10 minutes** to debate the other paper

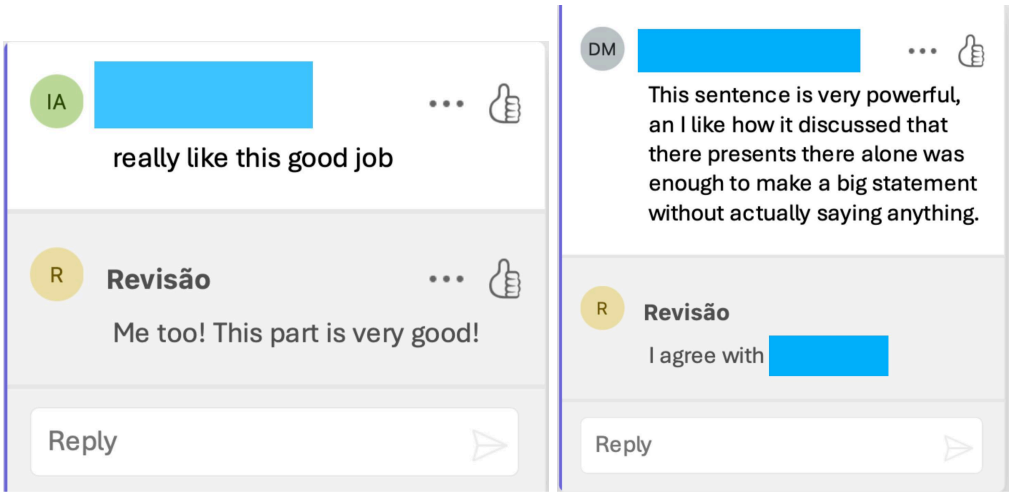
In the debate you can **expand** the ideas from your comment

After completing the activity, the class engaged in a whole-group discussion in which students shared insights gained from their peers' papers. Students were then asked to submit a revised version of their paper, incorporating feedback from their classmates, along with the peer comments themselves. This allowed me to assess not only the final draft, but also students' engagement with peer feedback and commenters' reflections on their own writing (see comments below). In my feedback, I often built on and reinforced the comments provided by peers (my comments below are signed as "Revisão").

- Students' comments on their classmates' papers:



- My interaction with the peer-reviewed comments:

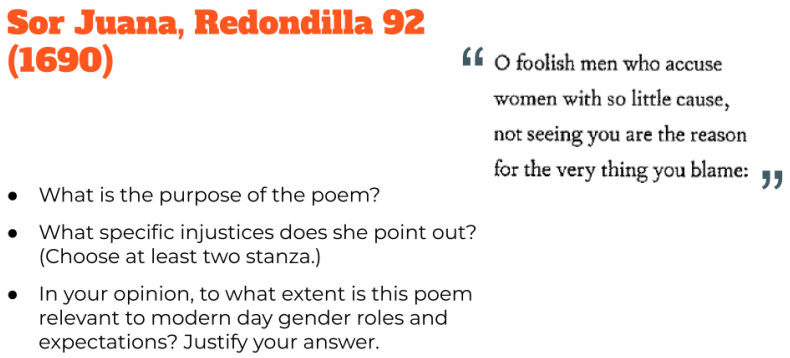


Artifact 3: Cross-cultural comparisons

Comparisons are a resource that I rely on a lot in the different classes I taught. All the activities below are answered in groups of 2-4 students.

a) **For cultural classes:**

Spanish 44 - Latin American Culture: We did a close reading of an assigned poem. Since the poem was from the 1600s, rather than asking students to compare Mexico and the U.S., I encouraged them to reflect on whether they still see patriarchal elements from Sor Juana's text in society today, regardless of the country. This approach invited students to connect historical literature to contemporary social issues and to share their own perspectives in discussion.



Portuguese 46 - Brazil and Portuguese-Speaking World: Students had watched a movie addressing domestic work in Brazil for the lecture. For the discussion, I brought in additional data about domestic work, relevant laws in Brazil, and recent changes in the field. After the brief introduction, I asked the questions below. During the lecture discussion, I noticed that students were visibly uncomfortable with what they saw in the movie—particularly class and racial discrimination, which are valid points—so I also encouraged them to reflect on inequality in the U.S. as well.



b) For language classes:

Portuguese 3: While we were studying the chapter "*O meio-ambiente*" ("The environment"), my state and city in Brazil were experiencing the worst flooding and natural disaster to date. This occurred in 2024, a year in which Southern California also experienced severe flooding. After a listening activity and a reading activity, which provided students with more context about what happened in my hometown, I proposed the following discussion questions. These questions invited students to compare and contrast both flood events, as well as the responses of government and society to these disasters.

Enchentes

Compare a enchente do **Rio Grande do Sul** com a da **Califórnia** (sul da Califórnia).

- O que **aconteceu** em cada lugar?
- O **governo** pediu que as pessoas **saíssem** de **casa**?
- Quem ajudou mais: o **governo** ou as **pessoas**?
- Como as pessoas **se ajudaram**?





Translation: Floodings
Compare the flood in Rio Grande do Sul with the one in California (southern California). - What happened in each place? - Did the government ask people to leave their homes? - Who helped more: the government or the people? - How did people help each other?

Spanish 2-3 (Intensive - Summer Abroad Granada Program): This activity was proposed during the study of the chapter "*¡De compras!*" ("Shopping!"). Before the activity below, students completed a listening exercise in which they were introduced to the concept of *regatear*—when it is appropriate to do so and how to do it in Spain. This was especially important to prepare them for practicing haggling in real-life situations. After becoming familiar with the concept, students were asked the questions below to compare this practice in Spain and the U.S., as well as to reflect on their own past experiences with haggling in the United States.

Los mercados tradicionales

a) ¿Se **regatea** en tu **país**?
b) ¿En qué situaciones?
c) ¿Alguna vez **regateaste**?
d) ¿Cuánto te **pedían** por el producto y cuánto **pagaste** finalmente?
e) ¿Te **gusta** regatear?



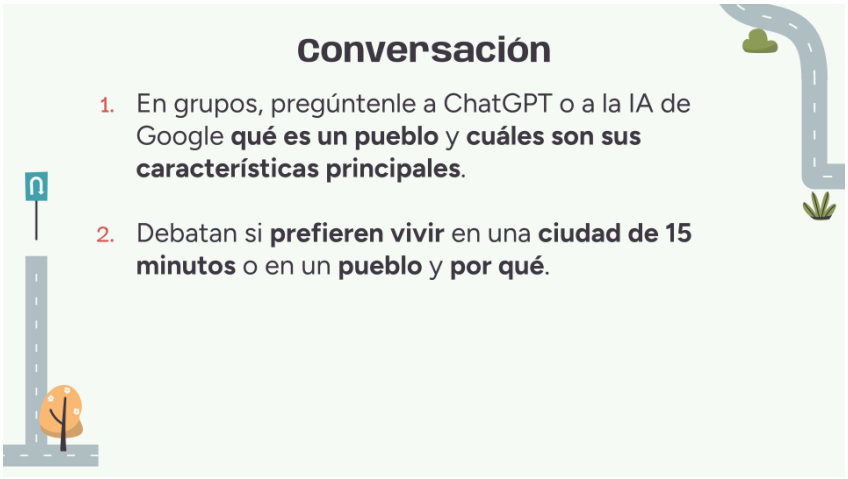
Translation: Traditional markets. a) Do people haggle in your country? b) In what situations? c) Have you ever haggled? d) How much did they ask for the product, and how much did you finally pay? e) Do you like haggling?

Artifact 4: Artificial intelligence

This artifact illustrates a discussion activity conducted in a Spanish 3 class, covering the chapter "*En la ciudad*" ("In the city"). In a previous activity, students had read about the concept of the 15-minute city, so this discussion built directly on that knowledge by encouraging comparisons. I also knew that they would be asked to define a *pueblo* in a future assessment. Rather than providing the definition myself, I decided it would be more engaging for students to search for a definition and debate it among themselves.

Asking students to look for the definition also helped save time, since they had already read a somewhat long text on the 15-minute city. This approach allowed them to find the exact answer without an additional long reading, while simultaneously reminding them that they can rely on AI tools to practice the language independently. Although I usually use authentic texts—written in the target language by humans, with few or no adaptations—for reading activities (as I did in the prior assignment), this method offered a practical and interactive alternative.

As with most group activities in my language classes, students worked in groups of 2–4. In addition to incorporating AI in the classroom, this activity demonstrates the centrality of active learning and group discussion in my teaching. At the start of the activity, I briefly reviewed the course's guidelines on the use of artificial intelligence, reinforcing best practices while clarifying that consulting AI tools was permitted for this particular exercise.



Translation: Conversation

1. In groups, ask ChatGPT or Google's AI what a *pueblo* is and what its main characteristics are.
2. Discuss whether you prefer to live in a 15-minute city or in a *pueblo*, and why.

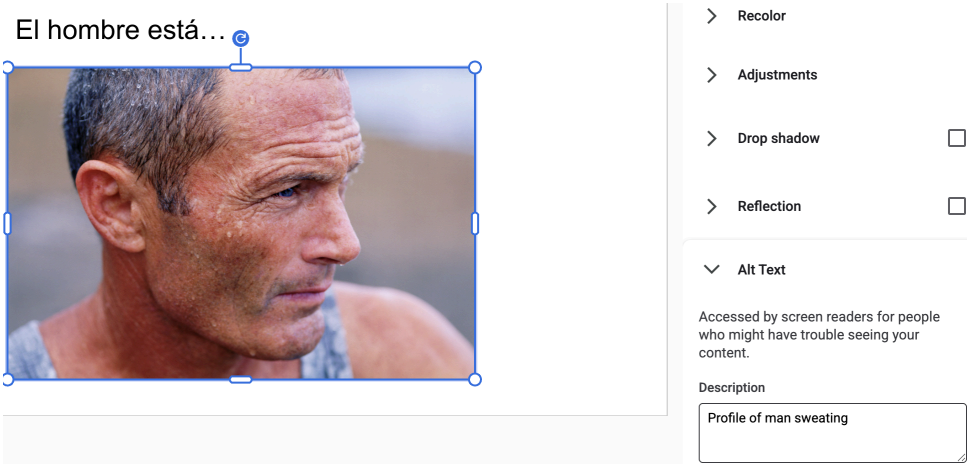
Artifact 5: Accessibility

Visuals are extremely important for language learning, especially for practicing vocabulary. However, I know that for blind students, it is generally recommended to avoid visuals in presentations unless they are essential. For this student, I removed most of the images from the slides I sent her (I would send at least one day before class, so she would have time to review them carefully).

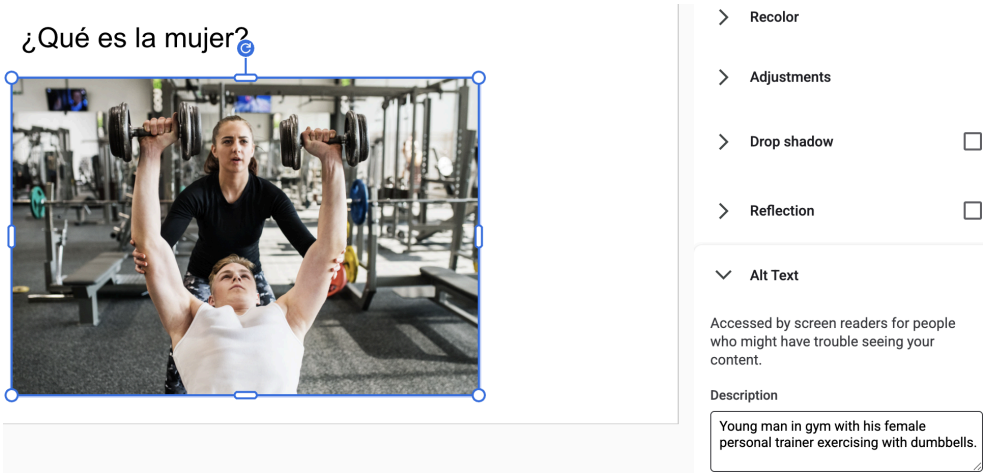
There was, however, one activity that I rely on heavily and conduct with the whole class. Typically, at the beginning of a chapter, I show students images and ask them to identify what each represents. This activity helps them practice and reinforce vocabulary they studied at home.

It was essential that this student could fully participate alongside her classmates and practice the vocabulary herself. For this reason, I maintained the activity, providing accurate alt-text in English for all images and following accessibility standards for screen readers.

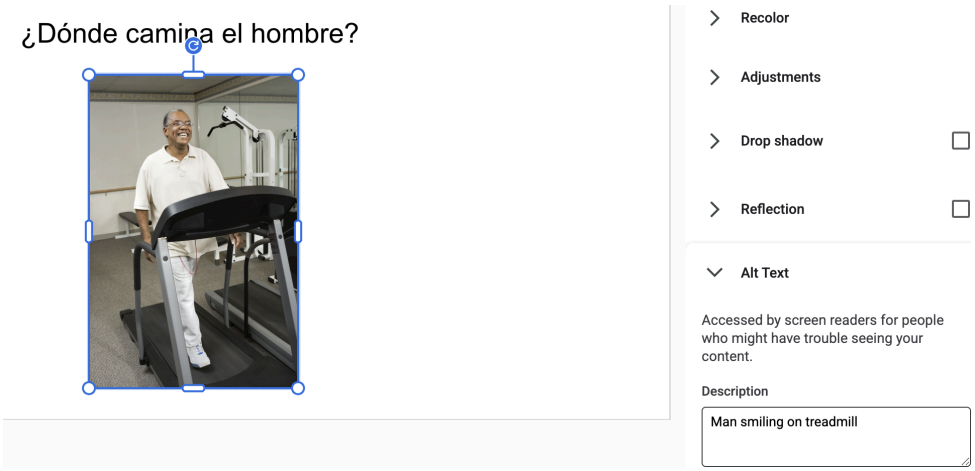
Here are a few examples of this practice, for the chapter "*El bienestar*" ("Well-being"):



Translation: The man is…



Translation: What is this woman's profession?



Translation: Where does the man walk?

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Jordan Bennett

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

- Raquel was a dream! I had her as my TA for my first semester at UCLA, so I was a bit discouraged and lost but she took the time to make sure I was successful. I will take all the future classes she has because she was so incredibly helpful.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

- Not only were her discussions extremely hands on and interactive, but she inspired us to make groups and talk about the material. This created friendships in the class and continued to outside and remain to this day. Her activities were fun and innovative especially with her approach to the subject matter, aiding in understanding particularly difficult poems and readings. With the short discussion time she was granted, she made sure everyone grasped the full concept of the curriculum and made comparisons or correlations to present day. In addition, I have a processing disorder, so it is a little difficult to understand certain notes especially in history when a powerpoint includes multiple countries. She went above and beyond to take hours of her own time outside of office hours to aid in further explanation of the class material. She always had the full focus of the class, and would get everyone involved in the discussion. She'd ask everyone within their chosen groups their own personal opinions so everyone's voices were heard.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

- She was also remarkably encouraging, and when I would get an excellent grade on an assignment she would add notes such as "good job, I am very pleased with your improvement" and saying things like "you should be proud." This is always nice to hear from a higher up, especially considering it was my first semester. Her kindness and support made me feel like I could be successful here despite being the only one of my siblings able to go to college. I wish all discussion classes would be set up like hers because the level of engagement kept our focus and speaking about the subject matter aided in our understanding. She would make an incredible professor as well with her warm and welcoming approach to questions.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

I am not the only individual that had this experience with her. She just wants the students to do well and tries her absolute hardest to get them there. Unlike many professors, she made you feel like there were no dumb questions. If you didn't understand how things were explained one way, she'd try to explain it in more different ways until you got it, never with any irritation or hostility. 10/10 would take her class again!

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UCLA Teaching and Learning Center

DISTINGUISHED TEACHING AWARDS

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students

Letter of Recommendation for: Raquel Zandomeneghi

Recommender: Juliet Falce-Robinson, Director of the Language Program

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I have known Raquel Zandomeneghi since Fall 2023 when she was a student in my Teaching Methods course. I supervise Raquel in her teaching in Spanish and Portuguese language classes. Raquel is an exceptionally competent, talented, enthusiastic and accomplished language teacher. Her dedication to becoming an excellent teacher is impressive and exemplary.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

I am inspired by Raquel's trajectory as a language teacher. After teaching all levels of Portuguese language and culture with admirable success, Raquel expanded her repertoire and generously contributed to department need by teaching Spanish language and culture courses with equal excellence and success. Raquel was selected as teaching assistant for our summer program in Granada and her contributions were phenomenal, both leading students through an intensive language-learning journey and at the same time playing a pivotal role in assisting the directors with logistics and program organization.

In the classroom, Raquel creates a space in which students immerse themselves in the language and culture and carry out meaningful communicative activities that enhance their abilities to learn and acquire the Portuguese and Spanish languages.

Raquel has regularly participated in university-wide and departmental workshops in a concerted effort to always grow and improve as an instructor. Most notably, Raquel is very dedicated to creating classroom spaces that are inclusive. As an example, Raquel worked closely with CAE to convert all materials, assessments and the entire learning experience accessible to a student who was visually impaired. Raquel truly provides a model of excellence for other teaching assistants, lecturers and professors in our field.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Raquel is particularly skilled in a proficiency-oriented approach and communicative method of language teaching. Her class sessions demonstrate her knowledge of the principles of student-centered instruction as well as her expertise and facility in incorporating authentic materials and technology in her teaching.

Students in her classes are inspired by her creativity and her unique ability to transport them to the target culture and allow them to communicate in the target language from day one. In Raquel's classes I have

witnessed the true joy her students feel as they realize they can understand and communicate in the language. Her classroom space is always warm, inviting and carefully constructed to support student success.

Raquel is very generous and demonstrates an amazing ability to successfully engage in collaborative projects with the other teaching assistants in the department. She regularly creates and shares activities and lesson plans with her peers. Even when she is not teaching, the students and the department benefit from her expertise and hard work.

Raquel consistently creates opportunities for students to connect to the language outside of the classroom as well. She conceptualized and co-founded the Portuguese language club and works tirelessly to promote language learning and student engagement.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Raquel's achievements as a teaching assistant and contributions to the Department of Spanish and Portuguese are beyond admirable. Raquel is, without a doubt, one of the candidates with the most impressive depth and breadth of experience and the most qualified that I have had the honor to support for this award. I would not only rank Raquel among the top 1% of graduate students and teaching assistants that I have supervised, but I would also honestly rank her as one of the best teaching assistants with whom I have worked, period. I offer the highest possible support and recommendation for her nomination without hesitation.